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16 Days of Activism: Stand against Gender-Based Violence

'GENERATION EQUALITY STANDS AGAINST RAPE'

Violence against women continues to plague our families, workplaces and various levels of our society. According to a survey by UN Women, gender-based violence or violence against women and girls, is a global pandemic that affects one in three women in their lifetime. In most cases, the perpetrators are their intimate partners or relatives.

An annual campaign titled '16 Days of Activism against gender-based violence' is observed throughout the world with a view to expedite the process of eliminating all forms of violence and generate awareness among people.

The campaign was initiated by activists in 1991 at the inaugural of Women's Global Leadership Institute, and continues to be coordinated each year by the Center for Women's Global Leadership. It is used as an organising strategy by individuals and organisations around the world to call for the prevention and elimination of violence against women and girls.

With different themes running each year, the international campaign kicks off on 25 November every year, on the International Day for the Elimination of Violence against Women, and goes on until 10 December ie, Human Rights Day. The global theme for this year is 'GENERATION EQUALITY STANDS AGAINST RAPE'.

Widespread incidents of rape have been reported in the national media in recent times, and this indicates the deterioration of rights of women and children in Bangladesh. According Bangladesh Mahila Parishad just in October 2019, 183 rapes and 465 incidents of violence against women and girls have been recorded.

Ensuring gender equality is paramount to ending violence. It is important to determine how Bangladeshi women are faring in the parametres of employment, social security, representation in politics, financial management and control over resources.

According to Global Gender Gap Report 2018 published by World Economic Forum, Bangladesh secured the second position among South-Asian countries in ensuring gender equality. The country is making significant progress in policy formulation and participation of women in higher management positions. According to Peace and Security Index 2019-2020 by Georgetown University's Institute for Women, Peace and Security, and the Peace Research Institute Oslo, Bangladesh ranked 142 amongst 167 countries whereas the position was 127 in 2017. Bangladesh's performance was reportedly unsatisfactory in the parametres of employment opportunity, legal discrimination and repression by husbands. This indicates how the overall development of a country suffers if steps are not taken to prevent violence against women and ensure their safety.

The government of Bangladesh has formulated and passed the National Plan of Actions (NPAs), National Women Development Policy, 2011 and Child Marriage Restraint Act, 2017 to prevent violence against women and children. In addition, the National Helpline number 109 is working ceaselessly to prevent gender-based violence.

BRAC's five year Gender Strategic Plan (2016-2020), has set a bold target to adopt an integrated approach into all of its programmes to combat violence against women and children, and bring down the rate of violence by at least 10%. BRAC is commited to include collective initiatives on violence against women and children and to involve the male counterparts for the empowerment of women.

Sir Fazle Hasan Abed, the founder and Chair Emeritus of BRAC, has always held close the dream of ending all forms of violence against women, and building an inclusive world free from all kinds of discrimination and social injustice. Let us unite to work towards that vision.

As always, BRAC will be taking part in the campaign against gender-based violence in association with local, national and international communities. For the campaign this year, let us take a vow to:

- Never harass or assault anyone, and to speak up if we witness anyone being harassed or assaulted
- Say 'no' to all forms of violence against women
- View all forms assault as a violation of human rights, and to report any such violations to the nearest office of women's affairs, law enforcement agencies, human rights organisations such as BRAC, or call 109 for assistance
- Provide mental support to a survivor of violence, and take a strong stand against the perpetrator